

## Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay

### 1. Purpose & example questions

#### Purpose

- To express your opinion on a **controversial** issue, arguing either for or against it
- Target audience — **students** (on the school newsletter), the **general public** (on newspapers and technology magazines)

#### Example questions

- *Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.*
- *Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?*
- *Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?*

### 2. Planning your essay

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| <b>Title</b>                     | <p><b>Choose ONE of three patterns:</b></p> <p>(1) Issue + verdict — <b>Social Media: More Harm Than Good</b></p> <p>(2) Question — <b>Is Social Media Doing More Harm Than Good?</b></p> <p>(3) Call to action — <b>Why We Must Rethink Social Media</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Introduction</b>              | <p><b>1. Hook</b> — one striking line, figure, image or short question<br/> <i>The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media.</i></p> <p><b>2. Narrow the focus</b> — link the issue to the audience<br/> <i>Social media is now ubiquitous and it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another.</i></p> <p><b>3. Stance</b> — ONE side, in one sentence<br/> <i>I firmly believe that ... / It is undeniable that ...</i></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Body paragraphs 1 &amp; 2</b> | <p><b>1. Topic sentence</b> — a signpost + the argument itself. <i>First and foremost, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health.</i> <b>2. Explain</b> — build a cause-and-effect chain (X → Y → Z)<br/> <i>Platforms are designed to reward comparison, so users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's lives, and they are encouraged to measure their own against them.</i> <b>3. Example</b> — Findings / Real-world case / Typical process</p> <p><i>Findings — "According to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety."</i></p> <p><i>Real-world case — France has restricted phones in its middle</i></p> |

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|                                                           | <p><i>schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a “digital pause”, requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. (Another: in November 2024, Australia legislated a minimum age of sixteen for social media accounts.)</i></p> <p><i>Typical process — Consider what happens when the app is opened for a five-minute break: the feed fills with classmates’ holidays and prizes, an ordinary evening is set beside them, and self-doubt follows.</i></p> <p><b>Never write these (a marker spots them instantly)</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• invented names ("my friend Jason", "a Form 5 student called Mary")</li> <li>• invented percentages ("about 87% of students")</li> </ul> <p><b>4. Round off</b> — echo the key words of the question <i>Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates the anxiety that many teenagers already carry.</i></p> |
| <b>Body paragraph 3 (counter-argument &amp; rebuttal)</b> | <p><b>1. Concede</b> — state the other side briefly<br/><i>Admittedly, ... / Some may argue that ...</i></p> <p><b>2. Rebut</b> — a concrete reason why the objection fails<br/><i>However, this argument overlooks the fact that ...</i></p> <p><b>3. Round off</b> — re-affirm your stance <i>To put it bluntly, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</i></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Conclusion</b>                                         | <p><b>1. Restate the stance</b> in NEW words — do not copy the introduction</p> <p><b>2. Summarise</b> your arguments in one line.</p> <p><b>3. Final thought</b> — a call to action.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

### 3. Sample writing — the format in action

**Question:** You have read an article in a local technology magazine claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an essay for the magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with reasons and examples. (about 400 words)

**BOLD** = persuasive language

Underlined = linking words and signals.

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| <p><b>Social Media: More Harm Than Good</b></p> <p>The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media. That time could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply talking to family. Social media is now <b>ubiquitous</b>, and <u>although</u> it promises connection, it <b>quietly reshapes</b> the way young people see themselves and one another. <b>I</b></p> | <p><b>Title</b></p> <p><b>Introduction</b><br/>Hook<br/>Stance</p> |
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| <p><b>firmly believe that</b> social media does more harm than good to teenagers.</p> <p><u>First and foremost</u>, social media is <b>detrimental to</b> teenagers' mental health. Platforms are <b>designed to reward comparison</b>, so users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's holidays and achievements, and pushed to measure their own lives against them. The evidence is <b>no longer in doubt</b>: according to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face <b>double the risk of depression and anxiety</b>. Day after day, this comparison <b>erodes</b> self-esteem and <b>exacerbates</b> anxiety — <b>harm that is easy to miss</b> <u>precisely because</u> it feels normal.</p> <p><u>Moreover</u>, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention <b>fragmented</b>, and <b>fragmented</b> attention makes deep reading — the very skill that public examinations demand — <b>almost impossible to sustain</b>. Late-night scrolling also delays sleep, <u>which in turn undermines</u> concentration in class.</p> <p><b>Governments have reached the same conclusion</b>: France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. When the loss is measured in attention and sleep, <b>convenience is a poor defence</b>.</p> <p><u>Some may argue that</u> social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. <u>Admittedly</u>, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a niche interest may find community online. <u>However</u>, these benefits are <b>superficial</b> when set against the costs. Connectivity available at any hour is precisely what makes it hard to switch off, and a following built on fleeting likes is rarely <b>mutual</b> support; at best, it is a <b>short-lived</b> substitute for friendship. <u>To put it bluntly</u>, the convenience is real but modest, <u>while</u> the harm <b>compounds</b> year after year.</p> <p><u>In conclusion</u>, social media is <b>not without value</b>, yet its effects on teenagers' well-being, concentration and self-image <b>plainly outweigh</b> its benefits. <b>Banning the technology would be counterproductive</b>; the answer is a deliberate effort to <b>curb</b> the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen <b>deserves their attention</b>.<br/>(408 words)</p> | <p><b>Body 1</b><br/>Topic sentence<br/>Explanation<br/>Example<br/>Round off</p> <p><b>Body 2</b><br/>Topic sentence<br/>Explanation<br/>Example<br/>Round off</p> <p><b>Body 3 — counter-argument &amp; rebuttal</b><br/>Concede<br/>Rebut<br/>Round</p> <p><b>Conclusion</b><br/>Restate stance<br/>Summarise arguments<br/>Final thought</p> <p><u>Total: 408 words</u></p> |
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| <i>Teacher's Note: the sample argues the <b>HARMFUL</b> side. For the opposite stance, keep the same skeleton — concede the harms, rebut with the benefits (access to information, community for isolated students, self-expression) and swap in foster, cultivate, equip students with, conducive, indispensable, tangible.</i> |  |
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| <b>4. Language features — five reminders</b>                                                                                |
| <i>Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing. <b>BOLD</b> = persuasive language. <u>Underlined</u> = linking words.</i> |

| Reminder                                                                  | ✗ Poor example                                                               | ✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)                                                                                                           |
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| <b>Formal vocabulary</b><br><i>no “super”, “stuff”, “a lot of things”</i> | Social media gives teenagers a lot of bad feelings and problems.             | Social media <b>exacerbates</b> the anxiety teenagers already carry and <b>erodes</b> their <b>self-esteem</b> .                               |
| <b>Passive voice</b><br>... be + past participle                          | Social media shows teenagers perfect lives, and this makes them feel worse.  | Teenagers <b>are constantly exposed to</b> polished images of other people's lives, <u>and</u> their confidence <b>is steadily eroded</b> .    |
| <b>Persuasive language</b><br>( <b>BOLD</b> )                             | Social media is bad for students. I think it is a problem.                   | Social media is <b>detrimental</b> to teenagers' mental health, and the harm is <b>easy to miss precisely because it feels so normal</b> .     |
| <b>Linking words</b><br>( <u>underlined</u> )                             | Social media is harmful. Students cannot concentrate. Their results are bad. | Social media is harmful; <u>as a result</u> , students can no longer concentrate, <u>and</u> their results <b>suffer</b> .                     |
| <b>One side, no “you” and no repeated “I think”</b>                       | I think you can see that phones are super bad for everyone.                  | <b>It is undeniable that</b> smartphone dependency <b>undermines</b> students' concentration, <u>and</u> the consequences <b>are serious</b> . |

*Teacher's Tip: project the poor example, let the class fix it aloud, then reveal the upgraded version. The underlined words are the ones that show the marker where the argument is going.*

| 5. Quick reference — linking words (underlined in the sample) |                                                                                                     |
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| Introduce and take a stance                                   | In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous.   I firmly believe that ...   It is undeniable that ... |

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|                                |                                                                                                 |
| <b>Open the first argument</b> | First and foremost, ...   The most serious consequence of ... is ...                            |
| <b>Add an argument</b>         | Moreover, ...   Worse still, ...   Equally worrying is ...                                      |
| <b>Give an example</b>         | For instance, ...   According to + [source] + ([year]), ...<br>  Consider what happens when ... |
| <b>Concede, then rebut</b>     | Admittedly, ...   Some may argue that ...   However, ...<br>  What this overlooks is ...        |
| <b>Conclude and end</b>        | In conclusion, ...   On balance, ...   The answer is not to ... but to ...                      |